FF / Delivery intake / Discovery

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2.1. Overview

The key difference between Fixed-Price projects and T&M ones is the fact that most of the risk is transferred to the vendor, where budget, timeline, deliverables, and, sometimes, a delivery date are defined up front. In this situation:

- The customer pays an agreed fixed amount irrelative of the actual cost incurred
- The biggest part of the agreed fixed amount is usually paid after the whole project is delivered
- Some contracts include penalties if not delivered on time.

The discovery phase is about defining scope, budget, resource plan, milestones and assumptions of the overall project in a bounded timeframe. Fixed-price projects require very detailed requirements specification to get fine grain and reliable costs and efforts estimate. Discovery is more worthy to get you into the customer business than to make a detailed spec. Adjusting rough estimate to solid estimate comes not after all risks are identified and technical decisions are done, but after you only got into some understanding of their business specifics and some of their data structures.

Checklist

Conception and initiation

Get all constraints about the project from your Account Manager/Pre-sales team:

- [ ] Is it a highly recommended to have a separate Fixed-Price contract for Discovery phase?
- [ ] Potential project start date and hard deadline for project delivery
- [ ] Get/formulate preliminary discovery scope to identify Key EPAM stakeholders in Practices
- [ ] Is it a separate project or part of a bigger program?
- [ ] Is it a new customer for EPAM?
- [ ] Staffing location restrictions
- [ ] Rates
- [ ] Additional services (consulting, L1/L2/L3 support, etc.)
- [ ] High-level budget for implementation
- [ ] Constraints collected from the customer (architecture, schedule, processes)

Pre-discovery initiatives - get as much information about the customer and expected solution as you can:

- [ ] Company background
- [ ] Business domain
- [ ] Company culture
- [ ] **Decision makers**
- [ ] **Key stakeholders**
- [ ] Internal processes (or their absence)
- [ ] **Business processes**, especially CR's approval/signing procedures
- [ ] Enterprise architecture where you need to place you solution in

Definition and planning

Build a discovery team, involving

- [ ] Validate if Presales team's engagement is required and engage if so
- [ ] Competency center or Practice
- [ ] SA/Technical Lead with domain knowledge
- [ ] SME or BA with domain knowledge

- [ ] Schedule communications sessions with discover team to finalize discovery plan
- [ ] **Discuss possibility to extend involvement of discovery team members up to the Project Implementation phase (ensuring continuity with practice/location Resource Managers)**

Develop a discovery plan which will include workshops planning and time to work on the product backlog and architectural documents

- [ ] Overview session, where business goals will be shared and explained to the whole team
- [ ] Architecture/Infrastructure
- [ ] Integrations
- [ ] Sessions for each functional area
- [ ] Project communication plan
- [ ] Set up all needed sessions with all the relevant stakeholders

Internal kick-off

- [ ] Get discovery team confirmation of feasibility of discovery deliverables in expected timeline and quality.

Get access to customer infrastructure

- [ ] Request access to the customer infrastructure, tools and source code repositories required to execute the discovery as soon as possible
- [ ] PII access

Launch

- [ ] Run the kick-off meeting with the customer (Discovery Kick off Template.pptx)
    - [ ] Handshake, introduce teams
    - [ ] Validate timeline, it's phases, major milestones and expected deliverables
    - [ ] Verify assumptions
    - [ ] Confirm main goals and expectations
    - [ ] Agree on governance
    - [ ] Agree on next steps
    - [ ] Follow up

Governance, Monitoring and Controlling

- [ ] Set up governance touch points (internal and external)
    - [ ] Report progress and roadblocks
- [ ] Bring to the customer intermediate results to make corrective actions of running the discovery
- [ ] Run iterative sessions with the customer to discuss intermediate results

Execution

- [ ] Solution architecture
    - [ ] Big picture of the system(s) landscape
    - [ ] High-level shape of the software architecture and how responsibilities are distributed across it
    - [ ] Technology choices and tech stack
- [ ] **Backlog, scope identification**
    - [ ] Run the session, collecting all the requirements and building the Product backlog - identify scope
        - [ ] the format of the requirements is clear and there is approval with a defined impact on timeline/cost
        - [ ] guidelines and standards are gathered, described
    - [ ] Understanding business scope
        - [ ] get access to customer's training environments of legacy systems and learn how to do basic business workflows themselves. If customers make these actions manually - learn how to do it in Excel or even on paper. **It dramatically reduces the probability of the 'scope creep', which is really not 'creep', but 'detailing'.**
        - [ ] **high-level vision**, with a success definition from the senior stakeholder's perspective
    - [ ] List **Functional Requirements (EPICs, Features)** with **assumptions**
    - [ ] Define **integration points** with **assumptions**
    - [ ] Define and confirm with the customer general test strategy and quality attributes including acceptance criteria, DoD, quality gates (if possible)
    - [ ] Check if any pre-defined release strategy is exist and should be followed
    - [ ] List **Non Functional Requirements (NFRs)**
    - [ ] List **out of scope functionality**
    - [ ] Voice out and document **all the assumptions/dependencies and their impact you have agreed on during the Discovery (incl. architectures assumptions)**- it will go to SOW for implementation

- [ ] **Analyze, qualify and estimate all risks** - it will go to overall estimation
    - [ ] General and project-specific risks
    - [ ] Specifically clarify NFR risks (pre-go-live assessment by any auditor, huge data migrations from legacy systems, etc.)
- [ ] Define automated and manual business processes that can be used in the project
- [ ] **Define and document key dates for dependencies**
    - [ ] Define end-date for architecture changes (all further changes will impact timeline/budget)
    - [ ] Data setup/Data import/Data migration readiness date
    - [ ] 3rd parties delivery dates
    - [ ] Check if any release windows exist and should be followed
- [ ] Collect methods that should be used during the project, if any take place
    - [ ] formally described estimation method
    - [ ] formally described re-estimation process after requirements are approved
    - [ ] categorization and prioritization (or severity) of bugs, format, SLA's and triaging process
    - [ ] process of reporting environment issues and SLAs defined assigned to the customer
- [ ] All Deliverables are described and confirmed with the discovery team and if possible potential (prescreened) execution key team members

> **PAY SPECIAL ATTENTION**
>
> If you haven't yet analyze the amount of effort to be conducted during the project or EPAM didn't actively participate in the pre-sale phase and didn't helped to form customer budget

Costs calculation (contingency included)

- [ ] **Resource plan**. During the planning of the team, workload don't forget to use focus-factor (non-production value activities that could be in place during Delivery). This factor significantly influence final schedule dates. It's good to have 30% for non-production activities.
- [ ] List **licenses** that should be purchased - it can impact project budget
- [ ] Check if **infrastructure** (for test and production environments purpose) costs required to consider and if so:
    - [ ] Estimate Infrastructure expected costs if possible through EPAM partnership with tools/services supplier
    - [ ] Define assumptions

- [ ] Create a sprint (period) based milestone project plan, which should have
    - [ ] Development start (and all further dates are relative to the development start date)
    - [ ] **Milestones**
    - [ ] Delivery dates for Themes/EPICs and/or if required for major Features
    - [ ] Delivery dates for all phases and also stages with the customer and 3rd parties (UAT, E2E, transition, etc)
    - [ ] Overall delivery date
- [ ] List estimates for the activities and phases
    - [ ] granular estimates provided by trusted technical subject matter experts. The estimates should be justified by technical and business assumptions against each functional and non-functional point
    - [ ] Try to challenge received estimations to get more detailed estimations. After a couple of times, you will find out the level of risk, that we should take into count and should list to discuss with the Account Manager.
    - [ ] You should merge the level of the risk into the final estimates. All the risks should be noted and not be as huge as possible.
    - [ ] Overall risk value shouldn't be more than 30% of original estimates. In case your risk is more huge - details the requirements and continue estimations and decomposition.

Delivery team staffing

- [ ] Create an opportunity/convert an existing opportunity to a project in Staffing Desk
- [ ] Create a preliminary resource plan in Staffing Desk: roles, primary skills, workload
- [ ] Add positions description
- [ ] Initiate staffing process with WPM team and locations/practices

Finalization and demo of outcomes and proposal

- [ ] Do an internal dry-run engaging BU, Account/Delivery, Practices stakeholders based on recommended proposal content:
    - [ ] Executive summary
    - [ ] Clarified Customer Key Stakeholders and decision makers
    - [ ] Solution architecture
        - Big picture of the system(s) landscape
        - High-level shape of the software architecture and how responsibilities are distributed across it
        - Technology choices and tech stack

- [ ] Requirements
    - Backlog with features descriptions, assumptions (**efforts limitations, boundaries**)
    - Integrations
    - NFRs
    - Out-of-scope items
- [ ] **General and technical assumptions lists**
- [ ] **Dependency register with impact and points of no return**
- [ ] **Risk register**
- [ ] Licenses
- [ ] Resource Plan
- [ ] Budget. Don't forget to add the margin rate to the final estimates (if you haven't done it earlier)
- [ ] Project Schedule
- [ ] Test strategy and Testing approach
- [ ] Change request flow agreement (including approval gates, accountable representatives, templates, etc.)

- [ ] Demo a final proposal to the customer
- [ ] Draft SOW, check with AM if required

2.2. Duration

Discovery duration totally depends on the Project size. It can start from 2 weeks (minimal recommended duration for Fixed-Price Projects) and last up to up to 3-4 months for complex multi-integrations projects (up to 30% of overall project duration).

The customer needs to show back some value from the project within short period, they don't trust vendors to run long discoveries, as vendors don't know their business and fail too often - risk of not having well-defined requirements and architecture after a long discovery is too high.

2.3. Useful Information

Artifacts & Examples

- Discovery Agenda (example)
- Discovery Template (example)
- Scope Baseline (example)
- Risk List (example)
- Standard Risk Categories and Risk Sources
- Risk Sources Categorization
- Milestone Plan

Tips & Tricks

Plan Discovery | Study Customer | Run the Workshops | Identify Scope | Identify Dependencies | Identify Budget | Estimate the backlog

Planning to minimize the chance of unexpected risks and dependencies

Going through already gathered requirements without the customer can be beneficial to find any missing information or any dependency that was not obvious during the workshops.

- During Workshop planning leave some time for internal syncs (1 day in the middle of the week) where you can carefully go through already gathered requirements and outline possible dependencies and risks

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FEEDBACK IS WELCOME

No labels

EPAM DMC
YAMMER COMMUNITY

GET ASSISTANCE

Request help or submit your ideas

Request SWAT and Delivery Assessment

Request Delivery and Productivity Analytics

I WANT TO CONTRIBUTE

If you want to contribute contact us

Initiative you can contribute to